



AWS Well-Architected Framework

Mergers and Acquisitions Lens



Mergers and Acquisitions Lens: AWS Well-Architected Framework

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Mergers and Acquisitions Lens - AWS Well-Architected Framework

Publication date: **May 15, 2024** ([Document revisions](#))

This paper describes the Mergers and Acquisitions (M&A) Lens for the AWS Well-Architected Framework, which helps acquiring entities align with AWS best practices and guidance in the six pillars of the Well-Architected Framework for workload integration and migration to the cloud. It identifies when sub-optimal practices are being used which may lead to technical debt, and offers prescriptive guidance on how to improve or remediate the sub-optimal practices. We address general design and integration principles, as well as specific best practices and guidance. This lens supports AWS customers at all stages of the mergers and acquisitions lifecycle.

Introduction

The AWS Well-Architected Framework helps you understand and assess the pros and cons of decisions you make while building systems on AWS. By using the Well-Architected Framework, you can learn architectural best practices for designing and operating reliable, secure, efficient, and cost-effective systems in the cloud. It provides a way for you to consistently measure your architectures against best practices and identify areas for improvement. The process for reviewing an architecture is a constructive conversation about architectural decisions, and is not an audit mechanism. We believe that having well-architected systems greatly increases the likelihood of business success.

In this lens, we focus on technical debt, modernization, intellectual property, and compliance analysis. The M&A Lens can be a foundation on which two organizations can find common ground based on AWS best practices. You should still consider best practices and questions that have not been included in this document when designing your architecture. We recommend that you read the AWS Well-Architected Framework whitepaper.

This document is intended for those involved in the M&A technical integration planning process, such as CTOs, architects, M&A leads, and other integrators. After reading this document, you should understand AWS best practices and strategies to apply when preparing to integrate two technical environments.

Technical integration is crucial for achieving synergy and value creation during mergers and acquisitions. It involves combining the technological infrastructure, systems, and processes of

two companies to create a unified technology platform. Without proper technical integration, companies risk facing disruptions in their operations, decreased efficiency, increased cost and loss of valuable data. In addition, guided technical integration can also provide opportunities for innovation and growth by leveraging the combined expertise and capabilities of both companies. Overall, technical integration plays a critical role in the success of mergers and acquisitions transactions.

The M&A Lens is created for companies to follow AWS prescribed best practices during technical integration, drive cost optimization, and expediate merger and acquisition value realization. This guidance drives architectural qualities that layer M&A specific best practices. This lens should be applied as an expansion to the AWS Well-Architected Framework. The output of both the AWS Well-Architected Framework review process and this lens is a report containing applicable best practices, including whether or not they are in use at the time of review. Customers can use these outputs to improve the impact and outcomes of their integration, and to engage with their own governance mechanisms in a meaningful way. Every mergers and acquisitions transaction is unique, which means different expectations, needs, mandates, and even integration patterns. Anyone responsible for delivering mergers and acquisitions integration must learn and understand the special context of that transaction to apply what is appropriate from this lens.

Lens availability

The Mergers and Acquisitions Lens is available as an AWS-official lens in the [Lens Catalog](#) of the [AWS Well-Architected Tool](#).

To get started, follow the steps in [Adding a lens to a workload](#) and select the **Mergers and Acquisitions Lens**.

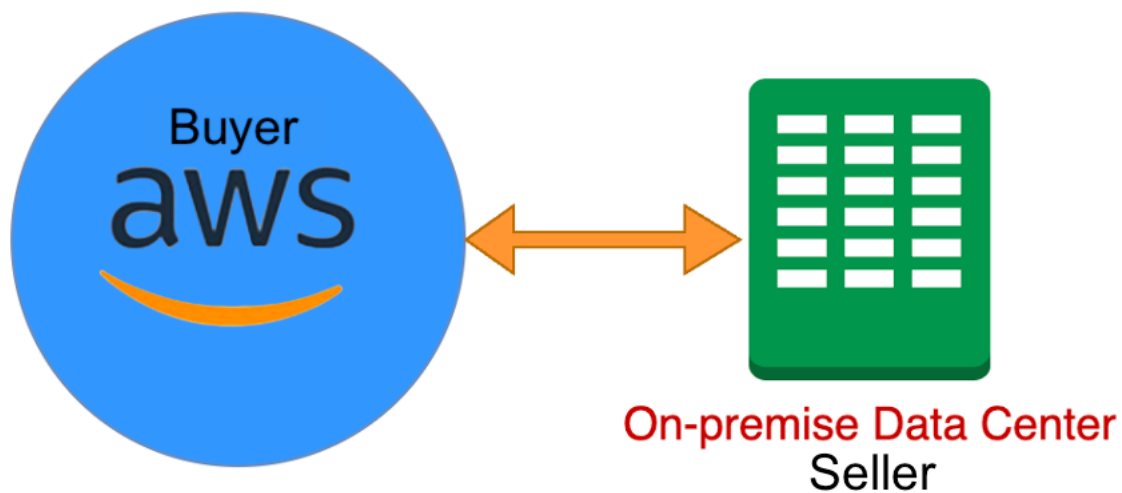
Overview

This lens helps with workload discovery and analysis for migration to AWS. We also provide a questionnaire to identify third-party integrations and any impact they may have (like licensing) in case of migration to AWS. This lens provides guidance on region selection, data transfer cost, workload costs, and usage patterns, as well as best practices for choosing saving plans for combined organizations and setting up a common payer account for optimized governance.

In this whitepaper, we focus on the following business integration scenarios. The Mergers and Acquisitions Lens provides guidance for each scenario based on the AWS Well-Architected Framework.

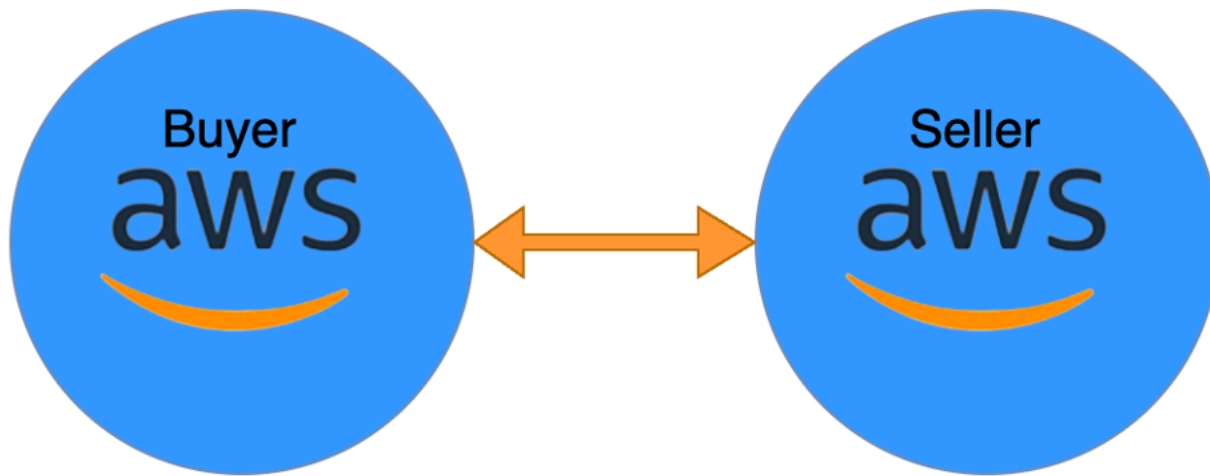
Business integration scenario A

The buyer's workloads are running on AWS, and the seller is either on-premises or on a different cloud provider.



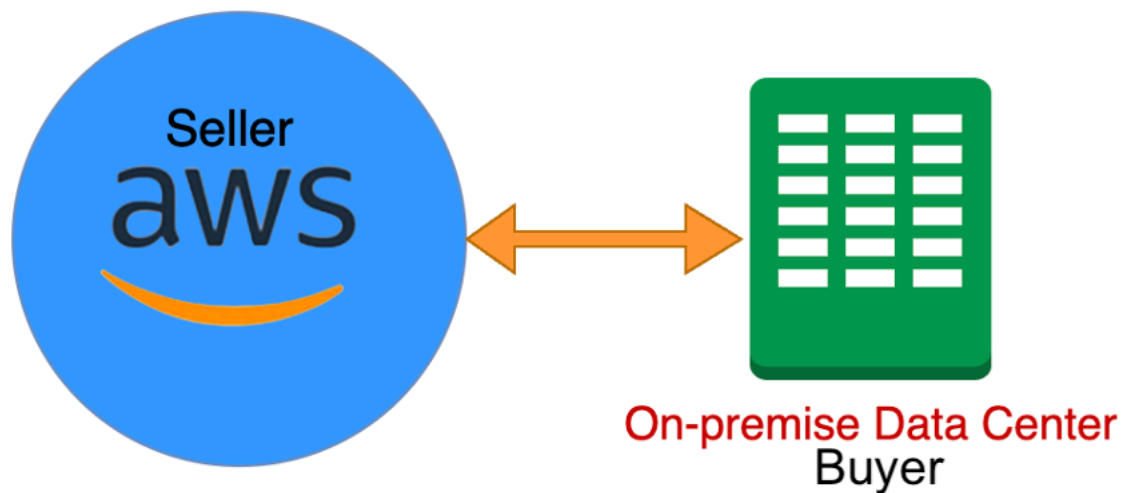
Business integration scenario B

Both the buyer and seller are running on AWS.



Business integration scenario C

The buyer is running an on-premises data center, and the seller is running on AWS.



The following sections provide an overview of the lens guidance, as well as potential use case scenarios and architecture models.

Overview sections

- [Operational excellence](#)
- [Security](#)
- [Performance efficiency and reliability](#)
- [Cost optimization](#)

Operational excellence

Scenario A

As part of integration, the M&A Lens provides guidance on the integration of major operational aspects (depicted in Figure 1) and more. Besides these operational processes, companies should look at other integration aspects, like project priorities, resources, skills, and culture. If the acquirer has AWS technical knowledge, they should lead the integration with AWS services. The acquirer should create a cost-effective plan for AWS migration with minimal disturbance to their end customers. The M&A Lens provides guidance to achieve operation process migration per AWS prescribed best practices.

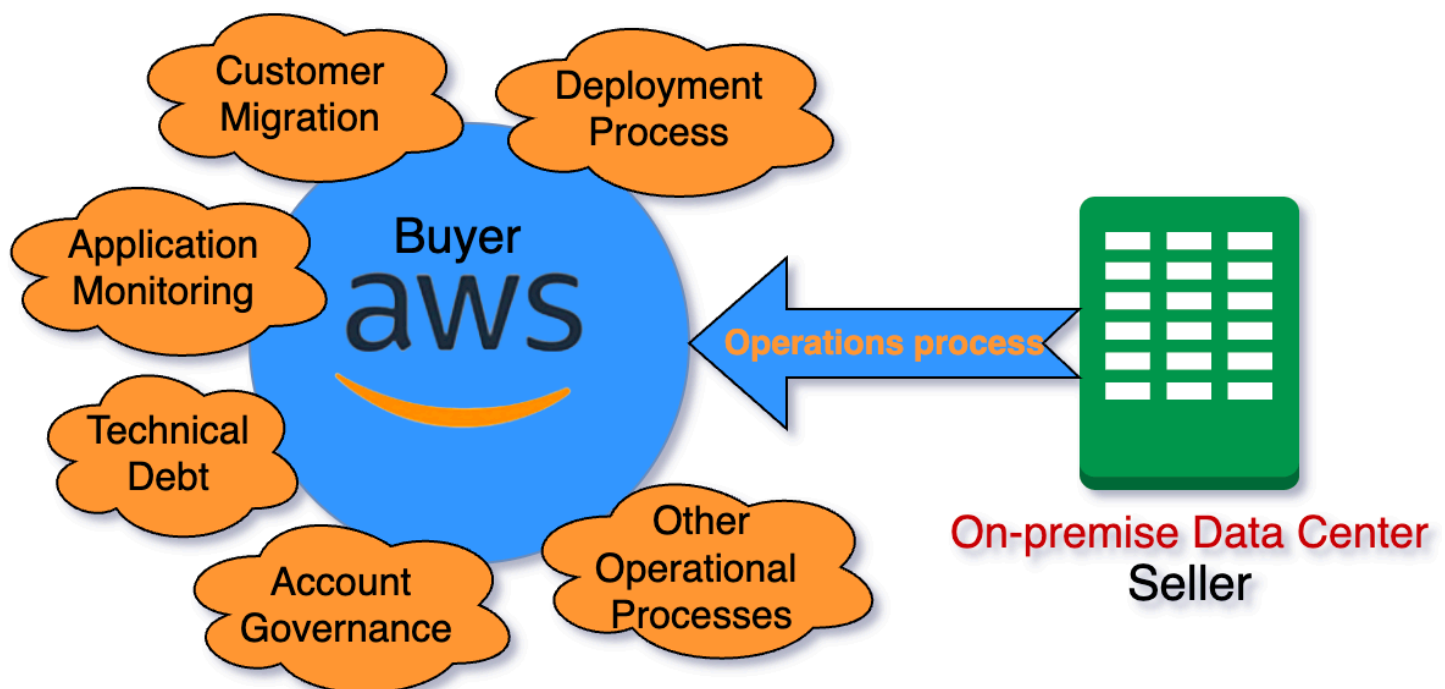


Figure 1: Model for AWS-aware buyer and on-premises seller

Operational excellence plays integral part during mergers and acquisition because of the following:

1. It helps identify synergies between the combining companies. By analyzing the operational processes of both companies, areas of overlap and duplication can be identified. Eliminating these can improve efficiency and reduce costs. Operational excellence helps quantify the potential synergies and cost savings from process integration.

2. It ensures a smooth integration of operations. The merging of two companies often involves integrating systems, processes, people, and cultures. Operational excellence provides a structured approach to identify core processes, standardize and optimize them, and implement them across the combined organization. This helps avoid disruption and maintain business continuity during the integration process.
3. It aligns goals and improves governance. As two companies come together, operational excellence helps clarify organizational goals, establish key performance metrics, and strengthen governance practices. This alignment and improved oversight are essential to realizing the potential value from a mergers and acquisitions deal.
4. It helps customer migration to the new platform with minimal impact to the end customers and extract benefit of cloud native technologies.

The M&A Lens guides customer regarding all of the preceding aspects, as well as specifics like:

- Management of application inventory
- Processes to mitigate and recover from AWS scheduled and unscheduled events
- Process implementation for security events
- Best practices for an AWS CI/CD pipeline
- Configuration management

In summary, operational excellence brings discipline, rigor, and a continuous improvement mindset to the mergers and acquisition process. This helps identify and capture synergies, integrate smoothly, reduce costs, align goals, strengthen governance, and sustain ongoing optimization.

In case the seller is AWS-integrated and the buyer is on a non-AWS platform, a similar approach can work. In this case, the AWS team can work with seller, who can take the lead for cloud integration.

Scenario B

In the case that both the buyer and seller are on AWS, we recommend best practices for multi-account governance, including setting up AWS Organizations. Consider setting up AWS Control Tower, which orchestrates multiple AWS services on your behalf while maintaining the security and compliance needs of combined organization. Additionally, consider resource tagging and integrating workloads to support end customers of the combined organization.

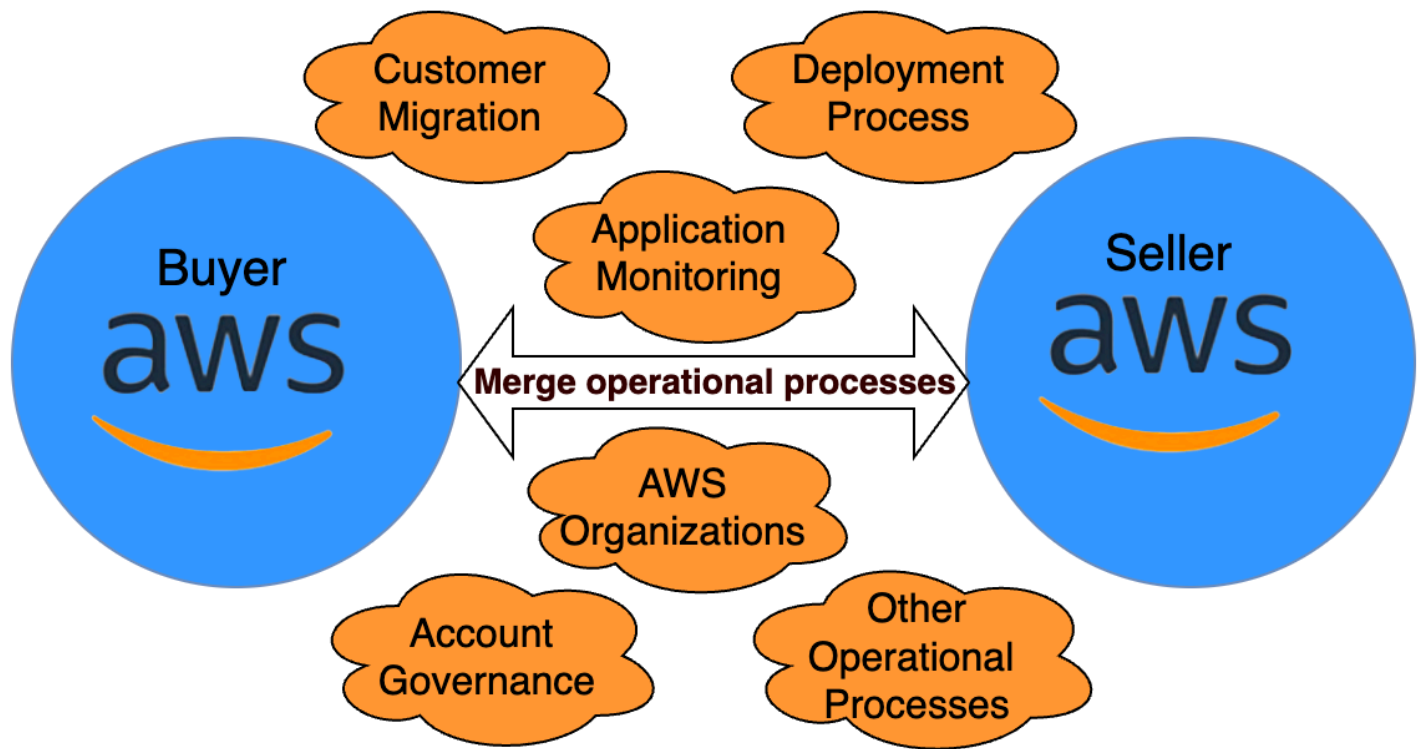


Figure 2: Buyer and seller are both on AWS

Here are some best practices for integrating operational excellence when conducting a mergers and acquisitions deal involving companies on AWS:

- Consolidate or organize AWS accounts and reduce redundancy. Merge separate AWS accounts and resources from the acquired company into centralized accounts controlled by the parent company. Eliminate duplicate services and resources.
- Standardize infrastructure as code (IaC) and configuration management. Both companies should be using AWS tools and processes like AWS CloudFormation templates, AWS Code Pipeline, and configuration repositories to deploy and manage infrastructure.
- Integrate monitoring, logging, and alerting. Unify monitoring systems, logging pipelines, and alerting mechanisms into a single platform that provides visibility across both companies.
- Consolidate support models, including Control Tower service control policies (SCPs) by using alerting, and then enforcement. Determine how responsibility for supporting the combined infrastructure and applications are handled across development and operations, site reliability engineering (SRE), and support engineering teams to remove redundancies. The goal is to drive operational efficiency by standardizing across people, processes, and tools as much as possible during integration.

Security

In mergers and acquisitions, the security pillar focuses on the security capabilities that are required to protect the application, identities, and data as they move between systems during integration. It is important to assess the security posture of the target organization and identify any gaps or vulnerabilities that may exist. This includes a review of the network infrastructure, applications, privileged access, monitoring, protection of data, security policies and procedures. There are several important security considerations during a mergers and acquisitions integration:

1. **Protect sensitive data:** During mergers and acquisitions, sensitive data is exchanged between the companies, including intellectual property, customer data, financial information, and employee records. It is important to protect this data through encryption and access controls. Any data breach during this phase can have major consequences.
2. **Integrate security policies and controls:** The merging companies likely have different security policies, controls, and technologies in place. It is important to review these and integrate them into a consistent and comprehensive set of policies and controls that meet compliance and regulatory requirements for the combined organization.
3. **Assess risks from new network connections:** New network, system and devices connections are established between the companies during integration. It is important to assess the security risks from these new connections and set up proper controls (like firewall rules and vulnerability scanning). Ensure new processes are developed for threat detection and incident response mechanisms and breach notification. Ensure privacy preserving mechanisms and strong data governance is in place against unauthorized access.
4. **Train employees:** Employees need to be trained on the new integrated security policies, controls, and processes to ensure compliance. Phishing simulations and security awareness training are especially important to reduce risks from social engineering attacks during transition.
5. **Monitor closely:** Mergers and acquisitions integrations significantly expand attack surface and risks. It is critical to closely monitor and act on any critical security findings, like unauthorized access, potential credential leaks, violation of least privilege access, data breaches, and malware infections. Security operations teams need to be on high alert and ready to respond quickly to any issues.
6. **Include security in mergers and acquisitions planning:** Security needs to be part of the planning and integration process from the beginning. Waiting until after a deal is signed to involve security teams can expose both companies to risk. Security requirements and risks

need to be evaluated before the deal, and a comprehensive security, privacy and compliance integration plan should be part of the overall mergers and acquisitions plan.

Best practices for data and application access, network connectivity, and data security are critical to ensure privacy and compliance for the combined organizations. This lens provides security guidance on best practices like:

- Establish security standards across combined organization
- Secure network communication for application integration across companies
- Monitor, detect and protect against security vulnerabilities workloads across combined companies
- Establish mitigation process to respond and recover from security incidents
- Define process to ensure privacy compliance as per combined company requirement

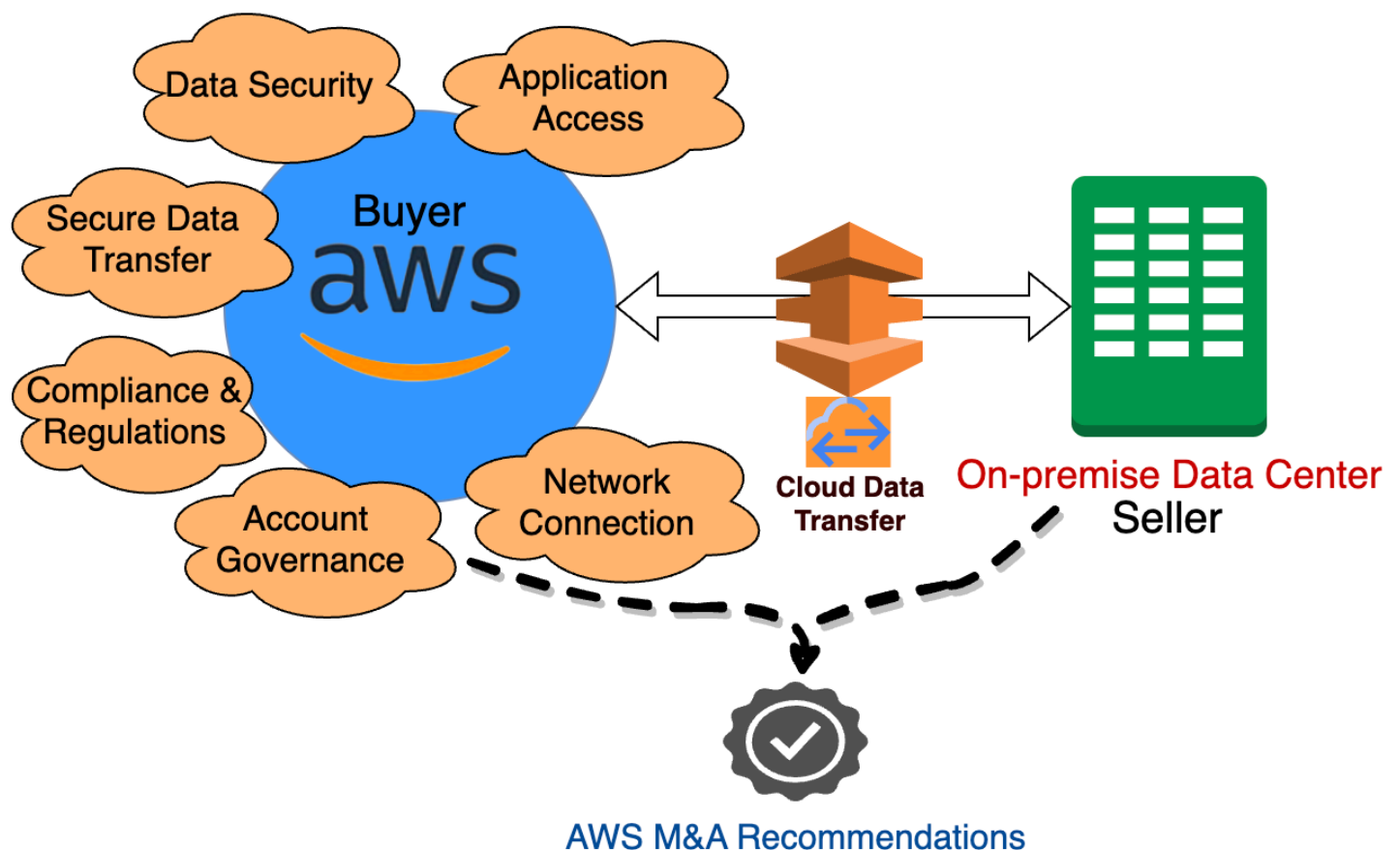


Figure 3: Security considerations for an AWS buyer and on-premises seller

Network connectivity is utmost to ensure data security and optimize data transfer cost. Design secure, cost-optimized network architecture using AWS services like AWS Direct Connect, AWS Transit Gateway, or AWS Site-to-Site VPN. We also recommend securing workloads and protecting applications from security attacks like DDoS, malware, and ransomware using AWS services.

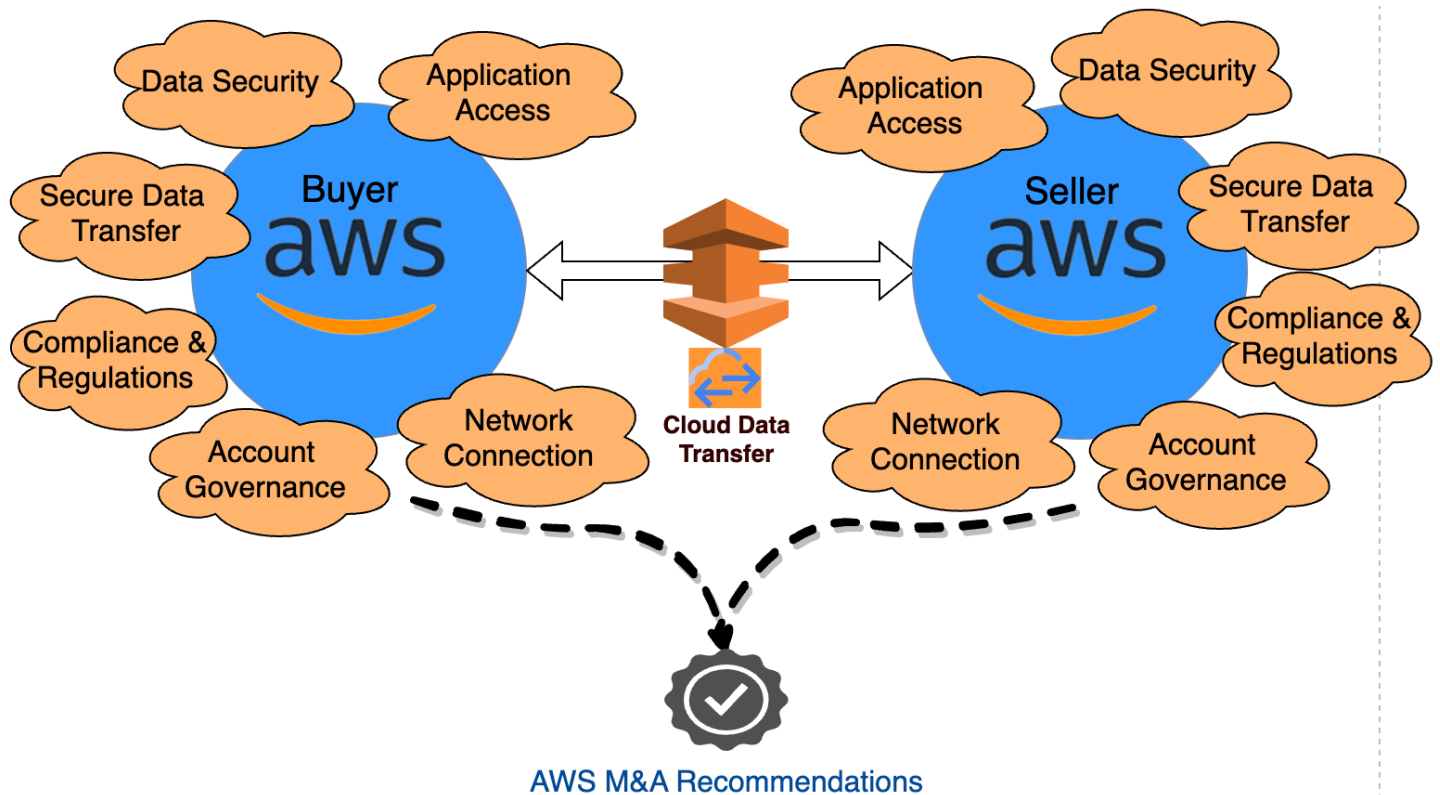


Figure 4: Security considerations for AWS to AWS mergers and acquisitions

In this scenario (as shown in Figure 4), customer should use AWS technologies for integration. Both buyer and seller have adopted AWS as their primary cloud provider. They need to establish secure network communication between multiple AWS accounts that may be within a single Region or between multiple Regions. AWS Organizations allows you to consolidate multiple AWS accounts into a single organization. This can be beneficial for a number of reasons, including:

- **Centralized management and governance:** Manage all AWS resources from a single console, making it easier to track and manage your spending, security, and compliance.
- **Security and compliance:** You can apply security policies and controls to all of your accounts from a single location, ensuring that your resources are protected and compliant with industry standards. You can easily securely share resources and services across multiple accounts, making it easier for your team to work together and collaborate on projects.

- **Cost savings:** By consolidating accounts, you can take advantage of bulk pricing discounts and optimize your resource usage to reduce costs.

One of the key challenges of integrating security systems and controls from different organizations is the potential for conflicts between different security policies and procedures. It is important to identify and address these conflicts before they become a problem. This may involve developing a unified security policy that applies to all organizations, or it may involve implementing AWS control tower that provides centralized management and monitoring of security systems and controls. Another challenge of integrating security systems and controls is the potential for data breaches and other security incidents. It is important to implement robust security measures, such as encryption, firewalls, and intrusion detection and prevention systems, to protect sensitive data and prevent unauthorized access.

By developing a comprehensive plan for integration and implementing robust security measures using [AWS Cloud Adoption Framework](#) approach, companies can uncover business requirements and securely integrate two disparate companies. This helps minimize the security risks during mergers and acquisitions and optimize overall integration time and cost.

Performance efficiency and reliability

During a mergers and acquisitions transaction, reliability becomes very important. This is because it is during the transaction that the two companies must merge their systems, data, and operations. Having a high level of reliability is crucial to maintain smooth business operations.

1. **Customer experience:** During mergers and acquisitions, there are many moving parts (like due diligence, integration planning, and customer communications), and it's critical to maintain a good customer experience. Any downtime or performance impacts to the applications and services that customers are using can reflect poorly on the new organization and damage customer relationships. AWS provides a highly available infrastructure, but the applications and systems also need to be architected for high availability to avoid any downtime. Combined organization workloads should be designed for planned and unplanned outages. AWS provides tools like Elastic Load Balancing, AWS Auto Scaling, and Amazon CloudWatch to help monitor performance and scale resources as needed.
2. **Scalability:** Mergers and acquisitions transactions often have uncertain workloads due to increased customer activity or data migration. The systems should be able to scale to meet these demands to avoid poor performance or outages. AWS provides a scalable infrastructure, but applications also need to be built leveraging auto-scaling and load balancing.

3. **Agility:** Strong performance means resources and workloads have enough capacity and are architected to allow them to scale and evolve as needed to support the business. This agility is especially important during integration due to uncertain capacity needs and constant changes in resource requirements. Poor performance means resources are being under-utilized or over-provisioned, leading to increased costs, impeded agility, and poor adaptability. Performance monitoring and optimization is key to managing costs.
4. **Operational efficiency:** Optimal performance means AWS resources and workloads are operating efficiently. This reduces the time and effort required by operations teams to manage the infrastructure, freeing them up to focus on integration. Slow or degraded performance can significantly impact operational efficiency.
5. **Risk mitigation:** Suboptimal performance of critical workloads poses risks to the business, such as loss of revenue, customer attrition, and reputational damage. Proactively monitoring and optimizing performance helps mitigate these risks during an integration.
6. **Data integrity:** As companies exchange sensitive data, it is important that the data is not corrupted or lost. While AWS provides mechanisms like Amazon EBS snapshots and Amazon S3 versioning to protect data, the systems also need to be designed to maintain and back up data properly.

In summary, to enable a successful mergers and acquisitions on AWS, reliability in all its aspects (availability, integrity, scalability, security, and cost management) should be designed and built into systems. With AWS, most of the infrastructure reliability is taken care of, but applications also need to leverage AWS services to achieve end-to-end reliability.

As part of integration, choose the right architecture that supports performance and reliability requirements for the combined organizations.

Scenario A

In this case, it is essential to establish availability (RTO and RPO) and SLA requirements for the combined organization. This lens provides guidance on the following practices:

- Managing robustness and availability of the applications
- External systems integrations and dependency
- Use of domain knowledge and intellectual property
- Data availability and backup strategy

Combined organization is likely to have more customers running on company workloads. Select an architecture that will allow more customer usage and drive company growth. It is critical to choose cloud native architecture that will scale per requirements. Similar guidance applies to scenario C.

Scenario B

In this case, this lens helps you perform customer migration with minimal impact. Choose appropriate DR options, including Region selection, uncover open-source dependencies impacting the reliability of the workload, and monitoring workloads based on availability and reliability requirements.

Cost optimization

The acquiring company needs to conduct thorough due diligence to understand the seller's costs and identify potential cost savings opportunities. One of the rationales for mergers and acquisitions is to achieve cost synergies through economies of scale. Pre-deal due diligence often does not uncover all sources of redundant costs. Integration provides an opportunity to identify further areas of overlap and cost-cutting through combining operations and standardizing procedures. Higher integration costs may mean lower returns and increased risk.

Cost consciousness is important to maximize value creation from mergers and acquisitions deals through both prevention of unnecessary costs and realization of synergy benefits. Managing costs during integration helps validate the business case for the deal and the projected returns to shareholders. It is important to optimize integration spending to deliver the cost synergies that supported the deal valuation. This lens provides guidance on cost optimization for a combined organization. It is especially critical while integrating systems that are on-premises, as data transfer and storage costs can increase due to an oversight.

Here are some key things to consider for AWS cost optimization during mergers and acquisitions integrations:

1. **Consolidate AWS accounts:** After an acquisition, there are often multiple AWS payer accounts and it is beneficial to consolidate these into as few accounts as possible to simplify billing and management. This can help identify unused resources and optimize costs.
2. **Standardize infrastructure:** The acquired company may have been using AWS in a different way with different standards. It is important to evaluate the two infrastructures and come up with a plan to standardize as much as possible. This could include standardizing instance types, using consolidated billing for discounts, or using common savings plan and choosing appropriate

Regions. Review resource usage to determine how many Reserve Instances (RIs) or which Savings Plans (SPs) can optimize costs.

3. **Review and optimize resources:** Once the accounts and infrastructure have been consolidated, review all resources in use to optimize costs. Look for unused EC2 instances, oversized instances, and orphaned EBS volumes. Optimize these as needed by rightsizing or removing unused resources.
4. **Monitor and automate:** Use tools like AWS Cost Explorer to get visibility into costs and usage over time. Set up budgets to monitor for any cost anomalies. Use automation tools like AWS Cost Anomaly Detection to automatically detect unused resources or major cost changes. Use AWS cost application tags to reconcile charges as per requirements.
5. **Train resources:** Train teams from both companies on best practices for cost optimization and governance. Share knowledge about how each team was using AWS and the best ways to reduce costs. Get everyone on the same page about how to architect in a cost-optimized manner.
6. **Continually optimize:** Cost optimization is an ongoing process. Continue to review new resources for cost effectiveness, look for new discounts or programs from AWS to leverage, and make cost optimization a priority across teams. Small optimizations made over time can add up to major savings.

Definitions

The AWS Well-Architected Framework is based on six pillars: operational excellence, security, reliability, performance efficiency, cost optimization, and sustainability. Mergers and acquisitions add a new dimension of considerations to each of these pillars.

Technology integration is critical to any merger or acquisition, and a successful process increases the likelihood of successful business value realization. We help you rapidly accelerate towards value realization by providing best practices for a cost-optimized integration and attainment of cost and revenue synergies. In this section, we present an overview of mergers and acquisitions concepts used throughout this document.

- **Mergers and acquisitions:** Mergers and acquisitions are corporate strategies used to combine or acquire two or more companies. *Mergers* are the combination of two or more companies into a single entity, while *acquisitions* involve the purchase of one company by another. In a merger, the ownership is usually decided upon by both parties, while in an acquisition, the acquiring company becomes the owner of the target company. Mergers and acquisitions are often used to achieve strategic goals, such as diversification, market expansion, and cost savings.
- **Divestiture:** A divestiture is the opposite of a merger or acquisition. It involves the sale or spin-off of a business unit or subsidiary by a company. Divestitures are often used to dispose of non-core assets or businesses that are not performing well. They can also be used to raise capital, reduce debt, or refocus the company's strategy.
- **Technical due diligence:** The process of identifying risks to integration, including data integration, workflow, technology stack mismatches, and feature set incompatibility. During this process, come up with recommendations for best practices to integrate, including AWS services to leverage for a seamless integration.
- **Integration:** The process of combining the operations, systems, cultures, and personnel of the acquirer and the target company after the acquisition is completed. It aims to achieve a seamless transition and maximize the anticipated benefits of the acquisition.
- **Operational excellence:** Includes the ability to run, monitor, and gain insights into workloads. It enables delivering business value and improves supporting processes and procedures. Best practice focus areas include organization, prepare, operate, and evolve.
- **Security:** Includes the ability to protect information, systems, and assets. It enables delivering business value through risk assessments and mitigation strategies. Best practice focus areas include security foundations, identity and access management, detection, infrastructure protection, data protection, incident response, and application security.

- **Reliability:** Includes the ability of a workload to recover from infrastructure or service disruptions. Ensures a workload performs its intended function correctly and consistently when it's expected to. It enables dynamically acquiring computing resources to meet demand, and mitigating disruptions such as misconfigurations and transient network issues. Best practice focus areas include foundations, workload architecture, change management, and failure management.
- **Performance efficiency:** Focuses on the efficient use of computing resources to meet requirements. It enables maintaining efficiency as demand changes and technologies evolve. Best practice areas are Architecture selection, Compute and hardware, Data management, Networking and content delivery, and Process and culture.
- **Cost optimization:** Includes the continuous process of refinement and improvement of a system over its entire lifecycle. It enables building and operating cost-aware systems that minimize costs, maximize return on investment, and achieve business outcomes. Best practice focus areas include Cloud Financial Management, expenditure and usage awareness, resource cost-effectiveness, resource demand and supply management, and optimization.
- **Sustainability:** Focuses on environmental impacts, especially energy consumption and efficiency, since they are important levers for architects to inform direct action to reduce resource usage. Best practice focus areas include Region selection, alignment to demand, software and architecture, data, hardware and services, and process and culture.

While this paper focuses on the details specific to mergers and acquisitions integration, refer to the [AWS Well-Architected Framework whitepaper](#) for more information on the Framework and its pillars.

Design principles

IT integration for mergers and acquisitions involves combining information technology (IT) systems and infrastructure of two or more companies to form a single, unified organization. There are several challenges that arise during this process, including handling different architectures, security protocols, governance models, and compliance requirements. Here are some of the common challenges that organizations face during IT integration for mergers and acquisitions:

- **Architecture differences:** The IT systems of the merging companies may have different architectures, technologies, and platforms, which can make it difficult to integrate them seamlessly. This challenge requires careful planning and analysis to identify commonalities and differences between the systems and to develop a unified architecture that meets the needs of the combined organization.
- **Operational differences:** The systems of the merging companies mostly likely have different operating processes and procedure. Creating synergy between buyer and seller company operations is a complex and time-consuming process. However, it is paramount to the integration success. They also need to consider the cultural challenges of merging two organizations, and have a plan in place to retain and attract the talent they need to succeed. Companies need to have a clear plan in place and acquisition the right resources to complete the integration successfully.
- **Security requirements:** Each company has its own security protocols, policies, and practices that may not be compatible with those of the other company. This can create security vulnerabilities and risks that need to be addressed before and after the integration. It is essential to perform a thorough security assessment and develop a unified security strategy that aligns with the overall IT integration plan. Both companies should use security technologies that easily integrate with and complement each other. AWS is an established platform with many security features, but it's important for companies to understand how to use these features effectively. The M&A Lens helps customers by prescribing security best practices for securing AWS workload during mergers and acquisitions integration.
- **Compliance requirements:** Mergers and acquisitions often involve the integration of companies that operate in different industries or regions, each with its own specific compliance requirements. This can create a complex compliance landscape that needs to be addressed to avoid legal and financial penalties. It is essential to perform a thorough compliance assessment and develop a unified compliance strategy that meets the requirements of both companies and regulatory bodies.

- **Governance models:** Companies may have different governance models for managing IT resources and decision-making processes. This can create conflicts and bottlenecks during the integration process, leading to delays and increased costs. It is important to establish a unified governance model that balances the needs and requirements of both companies and aligns with the overall business objectives.
- **Cost optimization:** Companies need to carefully consider the cost implications of an acquisition, including the cost of integrating the two companies' businesses and the potential impact on their financial performance. The cost of integrating AWS environments can be significant, and companies need to make sure that they are not overspending on AWS services. The M&A Lens helps customers by prescribing best practices for cost optimization during and after integration.

To handle these challenges, organizations often rely on a combination of technical solutions, process improvements, and cultural changes. One of the major strategies that organizations use to manage IT integration for mergers and acquisitions include conducting a thorough technical due diligence process to identify and assess the IT systems, infrastructure, security, and compliance posture of both companies. As part of technical due diligence, the M&A Lens drives technical integration depending on the following scenarios:

- **Scenario A:** The buyer's workloads are running on AWS, and the seller is either on-premises or on a different cloud provider. In this case, the buyer is cloud-conscious and should initiate the technical integration with the seller based on the AWS Well-Architected Framework pillars.
- **Scenario B:** Both the buyer and seller are running on AWS. In this case, it's beneficial to understand which company between buyer and seller is cloud native (for example, which is more advanced in their cloud adoption). In this case, the M&A Lens provides guidance on multi-account governance, reliability, security, and cost optimization. As both companies are well-versed in the AWS Cloud, the M&A Lens helps companies choose best practices for all Well-Architected Framework pillars.
- **Scenario C:** The buyer is running on-premises and the seller is running on AWS. It is essential to promote AWS benefits to the buyer during integration. The seller is cloud-aware and should initiate the technical integration with the buyer based on AWS Well-Architected Framework pillars. It is critical to architect seller workloads per AWS best practices so that buyer can realize the value of AWS. This helps the buyer adopt AWS services for cost optimization and overall value.

Operational excellence

The operational excellence pillar includes the ability to support development and run workloads effectively, gain insight into their operations, and to continually improve supporting processes and procedures to deliver business value.

Before the merger or acquisition, create a plan for how to handle operations. This plan should include a timeline for the integration process, goals for the combined company, and a list of tasks that need to be completed. Once the merger or acquisition is complete, create a new organizational structure that is designed to achieve operational excellence. This structure should be based on the goals and timeline you created. Implement the new organizational structure and make sure that everyone in the company is aware of their new roles and responsibilities.

Continually monitor and measure the company's performance to ensure that it is meeting its goals. Make adjustments to the organizational structure and operations as needed to improve performance. Once the company is operating at a high level, focus on continuous improvement. This may involve implementing new technologies or processes, or training employees to improve their skills.

The operational excellence pillar provides an overview of design principles, best practices, and questions. You can find prescriptive guidance on implementation in the [Operational Excellence Pillar whitepaper](#).

Questions

- [MAOPS 1: How do you plan to structure your company and processes to support mergers and acquisitions?](#)
- [MAOPS 2: How do you plan to set up and govern a secure, multi-account, or multicloud AWS environment?](#)
- [MAOPS 3: What is your combined AWS Organizations strategy, and how do you handle cross-cloud governance?](#)
- [MAOPS 4: How does technical debt hamper new feature development, hosting efficiencies, or cost reductions?](#)
- [MAOPS 5: Do you have a well-defined tagging strategy?](#)
- [MAOPS 6: How do you plan to use key industry domain knowledge, intellectual property \(like patents and algorithms\), and open-source tools after an acquisition as a barrier to entry?](#)

- [MAOPS 7: How do you plan to prioritize and develop a product innovation roadmap for the combined organization?](#)
- [MAOPS 8: Are product teams from both organizations aligned with the deal rationale and how to organize themselves internally?](#)
- [MAOPS 9: How do combined product teams organize their product hypothesis, prototyping, and testing with customer validation?](#)
- [Resources](#)

MAOPS 1: How do you plan to structure your company and processes to support mergers and acquisitions?

Both organizations involved in mergers and acquisitions activity must understand their part in achieving business outcomes. An organizational model that is optimized for cloud adoption should be established for the delivery and operation of cloud-based solutions. Both companies might need to extend or modify their structure in order to adopt the cloud, and the changes must be carefully managed in partnership with combined organization teams. Understanding responsibility, ownership, how decisions are made, and who has authority to make decisions helps focus efforts and maximizes the benefits from your teams.

MAOPS01-BP01 Workloads from both organizations have identified owners

Strong governance and centralized control over scope of migration workloads facilitates a successful migration. Wide distribution makes migration more difficult (assuming the migration scope spans these distributed groups).

MAOPS01-BP02 Processes and procedures have identified owners

Understand who has ownership of the definition of individual processes and procedures, why those specific process and procedures are used, and why that ownership exists. To better identify improvement opportunities, understand the reasons that specific processes and procedures are used.

MAOPS01-BP03 Operations activities have identified owners responsible for their performance

Understand who has responsibility to perform specific activities on defined workloads and why that responsibility exists. Understanding who has responsibility to perform activities informs who conducts the activity, validates the result, and provides feedback to the owner of the activity.

MAOPS01-BP04 Create a Cloud Center of Excellence team

Understand the responsibilities of your role and how you contribute to business outcomes, as this knowledge informs the prioritization of your tasks and why your role is important. This understanding helps team members recognize needs and respond appropriately.

MAOPS01-BP05 Mechanisms exist to request process additions, changes, and exceptions

You are able to make requests to owners of processes, procedures, and resources. Make informed decisions to approve requests where they have been deemed viable and appropriate after an evaluation of benefits and risks.

MAOPS01-BP06 Both companies have identified the cloud skills and competencies to enable the resources

Identify gaps between required skills and competencies and what is presently available in the organization. For existing staff, provide access to training courses of different types (both classroom-based and online courses). Encourage staff to obtain certification on cloud competencies to validate their knowledge.

MAOPS 2: How do you plan to set up and govern a secure, multi-account, or multicloud AWS environment?

Businesses that are expanding their footprint on AWS due to mergers and acquisitions, or are planning to enhance an established AWS environment, need have a foundation on AWS for their cloud environment. Establishing a cloud foundation on AWS requires guidance tailored to your business needs. Using a capability-based approach, you can create an environment to deploy, operate, and govern your workloads. A capability includes a definition, scenarios, opinionated guidance, and supporting automation to establish and operate a specific part of a

cloud environment. Capabilities are components that can help you plan, implement, and operate your cloud environment, and include people, process, and technology considerations. Capabilities are designed to integrate into your overall technology environment.

MAOPS02-BP01 Each company has identified their primary Region

For many services, you can choose an AWS Region that specifies where your resources are managed. Regions are sets of AWS resources located in the same geographical area. You don't need to choose a Region for the AWS Management Console or for some services, such as AWS Identity and Access Management.

MAOPS02-BP02 Configure AWS Control Tower, AWS Config, and AWS CloudFormation

AWS Control Tower offers the easiest way to set up and govern a secure, multi-account AWS environment. It establishes a landing zone that is based on best-practices blueprints, and it enables governance using guardrails you can choose from a pre-packaged list.

MAOPS02-BP03 Automate infrastructure as code (IaC) using CloudFormation or Terraform

AWS CloudFormation helps you model, provision, and manage AWS and third-party resources by treating infrastructure as code.

MAOPS02-BP04 Automate resource compliance using tools like AWS Config

AWS Config is a config tool that helps you assess, audit, and evaluate the configurations and relationships of your resources.

MAOPS 3: What is your combined AWS Organizations strategy, and how do you handle cross-cloud governance?

With accounts in AWS Organizations, you can easily allocate resources, group accounts, and apply governance policies to accounts or groups. Buyer organization structure needs to be extendible to accommodate new organization structure. Both involved organizations should come up with the right structure to support operational excellence.

MAOPS03-BP01 Structure your organization following AWS best practices

A well-architected multi-account strategy helps you innovate faster in AWS, while helping you meet your security and scalability needs.

MAOPS03-BP02 Merge the management accounts of both organizations

Consolidated billing is a feature of AWS Organizations. You can use the management account of your organization to consolidate and pay for all member accounts. In consolidated billing, management accounts can also access the billing information, account information, and account activity of member accounts in their organization. This information may be used for services such as AWS Cost Explorer, which can help management accounts improve their organization's cost performance.

MAOPS03-BP03 Determine if it's appropriate to separate management accounts

If there is a use case to keep OUs separate, you can certainly do that with multiple management accounts. There may be few reasons to keep Organizations separate:

1. AWS GovCloud (US) or commercial cloud
2. Differing financial needs, including taxation (Europe compared to the US)
3. Differing operating scope (Systems Manager)

MAOPS03-BP04 Merge logging, security, and infrastructure organizations

The approach covered in this pattern is suitable for customers who have multiple AWS accounts with AWS Organizations and are now encountering challenges when using AWS Control Tower, a landing zone, or account vending machine services to set up baseline guardrails in their accounts.

MAOPS03-BP05 Define a backup strategy for each organization

Use AWS Backup to create backup plans that define how to back up your AWS resources. The rules in the plan include a variety of settings, such as backup frequency, the time window during which

the backup occurs, the AWS Region containing the resources to back up, and the vault in which to store the backup.

MAOPS 4: How does technical debt hamper new feature development, hosting efficiencies, or cost reductions?

Technical debt of the platform is a distraction and limits the ability to devote time to more significant innovations or feature additions that could otherwise drive company growth. Organizational technical debt could be unintentional due to mergers and acquisitions activity. These organizations need to work towards consolidating these processes, structures, cloud-native tools, and buyer needs to understand the efforts needed to reduce or remove this technical debt.

MAOPS04-BP01 Standardize documented operational processes (like CI/CD and deployment)

Organizations incur operational tech debt during mergers and acquisitions. Organizations should remove manual processes and focus on automation.

MAOPS04-BP02 Retire or consolidate redundant apps and data-stores

Perform technical analysis during mergers and acquisitions. Otherwise, data and systems can be duplicated, or even potentially orphaned. Both organizations should agree on a consistent data model, consistent accesses, and compliance needs.

MAOPS04-BP03 Have a process in place for customer migration (if necessary)

Customer retention and migration is of utmost importance during mergers and acquisitions. It is critical to support existing customers with optimal costs and negligible impact. The AWS ISV Workload Migration Program (WMP) supports software partners that have a SaaS offering on AWS to drive and deliver workload migrations. Use funding, technical enablement, and go-to-market support to rapidly migrate customers to your SaaS offering.

MAOPS04-BP04 Understand third-party integrations and dependencies

It might happen that companies merge or multiple platforms get developed over time and duplicate some of the same needed subsystems. Being service oriented and consolidating services reduces the amount of code to be maintained.

MAOPS04-BP05 Perform all customizations through configuration, and change them as self-serve or company-controlled feature flags

Customizations that are done with configuration do not require a code recompile or reload. It is a way to get away from the legacy practice of making hard-coded customizations per individual customers or segments. Use feature flags that are temporary or permanent. These flags help during testing or canary release.

MAOPS 5: Do you have a well-defined tagging strategy?

Tags are key and value pairs that act as metadata for organizing your AWS resources. With most AWS resources, you have the option of adding tags during creation. Tags can help you manage, identify, organize, search for, and filter resources. You can create tags to categorize resources by purpose, owner, environment, or other criteria.

MAOPS05-BP01 Configure AWS resource tags

AWS resources can be tagged for a variety of purposes, from implementing a cost allocation strategy to supporting automation or authorizing access to AWS resources. Implementing a tagging strategy can be challenging for some organizations, owing to the number of stakeholder groups involved and considerations such as data sourcing and tag governance.

MAOPS05-BP02 Group applications based on tags

A tag is a label that you assign to an AWS resource. A tag consists of a key and a value, both of which you define. For example, if you have two EC2 instances, you might assign both a tag key of `Stack`. But the value of `Stack` might be `Testing` for one and `Production` for the other.

MAOPS05-BP03 Associate tags with each configured resource (during provisioning)

AWS CloudFormation provides a common language for provisioning all the infrastructure resources in your AWS environment. For AWS resources using CloudFormation templates, you can use the CloudFormation Resource Tags property to apply tags to supported resource types upon creation. Managing the tags as well as the resources with IaC helps create consistency.

MAOPS05-BP04 Set up security based on tags

Organizations have varying needs and obligations to meet regarding the appropriate handling of data storage and processing. Data classification is an important precursor for several use cases, such as access control, data retention, data analysis, and compliance.

MAOPS05-BP05 Perform cost allocation based on tags

The AWS-generated tag created by is a tag that AWS defines and applies to supported AWS resources for cost allocation purposes. User-defined tags are tags that you define, create, and apply to resources. After you have created and applied the user-defined tags, you can activate by using the AWS Cost Management Console for cost allocation tracking.

MAOPS 6: How do you plan to use key industry domain knowledge, intellectual property (like patents and algorithms), and open-source tools after an acquisition as a barrier to entry?

Determine what significant domain knowledge and intellectual property you have. Patents and key algorithms can create a barrier to existing or upcoming competitors to help protect company growth.

Innovative use of open source can save development time and increase the quality of the code. During technical due diligence, evaluate the target company's use of open-source software and intellectual property to identify any potential risks or liabilities. This includes reviewing license agreements, copyright notices, and source code to understand the extent of usage and any potential infringement.

Identify any gaps in your own knowledge or intellectual property (IP) compared to the target company. This can help you determine what areas require additional investment or attention after the acquisition. Develop a plan for integrating the target company's IP and knowledge into your existing operations, including any necessary adjustments to processes, systems, or products.

Consider the potential benefits of open-sourcing certain parts of the acquired company's technology, such as increasing collaboration, attracting new developers, and improving the overall quality of the codebase. Align the acquisition with your overall strategic goals and objectives, and verify that the acquired company's IP and knowledge help you achieve those goals. Work with legal and intellectual property experts to negotiate and structure the acquisition deal in a way that protects your interests and minimizes any potential risks.

MAOPS06-BP01 The seller has an extensive list of all IP and key innovations (and related documentation)

Use industry domain knowledge, as well as patentable and other relevant code innovations, to create a platform offering that is truly unique and valuable to customers.

MAOPS06-BP02 Document open-source software integrations

Continually evolve your underlying code base to build up capabilities that use open-source software where appropriate.

MAOPS06-BP03 Hold patents on key platform technologies

Patents are a way to secure your rights to innovative technologies that keep you in a competitive position.

MAOPS 7: How do you plan to prioritize and develop a product innovation roadmap for the combined organization?

Technical and market innovation roadmaps are essential to keep from growing stagnant in the market place and to drive growth. Roadmaps help provide product market differentiation.

MAOPS07-BP01 Document duplicate workloads and features

Keep a centralized list of work that could be epic-level ideas down to more detailed work for features, bugs, technical debt, and innovative advances.

MAOPS07-BP02 Identify the impact of product features on customers from both companies

A company should be looking beyond the current near-term features going in to strategically plan out longer term initiatives and how they can be ordered to create a compelling list of innovations.

MAOPS07-BP03 Document a combined-products strategy

Identify products to be retired, maintained, or enhanced. Document customer impact and migration plan in case of product or workload decommission.

MAOPS07-BP04 Verify that teams understand critical customer requirements

Increased decomposition for engineering tasks corresponds to increased probability of success. You can properly scope the effort in terms of cost, time, and resources needed, and define a definition for completion of work.

MAOPS07-BP05 Modify your existing roadmap to incorporate the new organization

Define the new product roadmap that aligns with the combined companies' goals. Determine customer impact based on product priorities.

MAOPS 8: Are product teams from both organizations aligned with the deal rationale and how to organize themselves internally?

Synergies in product, technology, and the market are often cited in the deal rationale for mergers and acquisitions. Consider how the different product teams might collaborate, as well as the friction points or the obstacles they might encounter.

MAOPS08-BP01 Document mechanisms for both product teams to operate collaboratively

Understanding deal rationale (for example, to acquire new capabilities or to capture market share). It's important for product teams from both companies to work closely to achieve the unified organization's goals.

MAOPS08-BP02 Verify that key product teams have a post-integration product strategy in place

Ensure product teams from both companies understand combined product strategy.

MAOPS08-BP03 Review, retire, and promote products and roadmaps based on customer focus

Product managers speak to customers regularly. The teams collaborate on the analyzed findings, and experimentation at scale is performed using well-known mechanisms. Manage data and cloud-enabled offerings that deliver repeatable value to internal and external customers as products through their lifecycles.

MAOPS 9: How do combined product teams organize their product hypothesis, prototyping, and testing with customer validation?

Mergers and acquisitions can impact the ability to perform both qualitative and quantitative experiments with consumers and customers, test agility maturity, and disrupt a product-led growth approach. To create smooth product releases and shorten roadmap lead times, provide your teams the ability to carefully and deliberately self-disrupt through innovation and experimentation with direct access to customers, without having to navigate major bottlenecks posed by either processes or technology.

MAOPS09-BP01 Create a Configuration Management Database (CMDB) or infrastructure repository

Implement automated mechanisms to update data and maintain data accuracy.

Resources

- [Account migration when transitioning to a multi-account architecture](#)
- [AWS Control Tower](#)
- [Building your tagging strategy](#)
- [Workloads and environments](#)

Key AWS services

- [AWS Organizations](#)

- [AWS Control Tower](#)
- [Guidance for Tagging on AWS](#)

Security

The security pillar encompasses the ability to protect data, systems, and assets by taking advantage of cloud technologies.

During integration, a well-defined plan is important to integrate identities from both companies without any impact to users. It is critical to have an integration plan to avoid security and compliance issues after mergers and acquisitions. Both organizations involved in mergers and acquisitions activity must understand the other's data and network security posture to integrate workloads naturally. Both organizations need to work on merging or adapting to incidence response processes. Data privacy, security, and integrity need to be handled without any issues during integration.

- **Access control:** Integrating user access across different systems can lead to difficulties in managing permissions and ensuring proper access controls. This could result in unauthorized users gaining access to sensitive information.
- **Network security:** Merging networks can expose the organization to potential vulnerabilities. Incompatible security protocols and configurations may create weak points that attackers can exploit.
- **Compliance and regulations:** Merging companies often have different compliance requirements. Ensuring the integrated IT systems meet various industry regulations and standards can be complex and challenging.

During mergers and acquisitions, it is critical to identify and mitigate any integration security concerns. This involves conducting thorough due diligence on the target company to identify any potential security vulnerabilities, weaknesses, or risks. Once identified, these risks must be addressed through a combination of policies, procedures, and technologies to ensure that the merged organizations are secure.

Some of the key integration security concerns during mergers and acquisitions include:

- **Data security:** Protecting sensitive data during the transfer and integration process, such as customer information, intellectual property, and financial data.
- **Network security:** Protecting the network infrastructure and ensuring that it is secure and robust enough to support the combined organization's needs.

- **Employee access:** Providing appropriate access to employees from both companies to the systems and data they need to perform their jobs, while preventing unauthorized access.
- **Third-party vendors:** Managing the security risks associated with third-party vendors that the merged organization uses to provide services or support.
- **Regulatory compliance:** Complying with all relevant regulatory requirements, such as HIPAA, PCI DSS, and GDPR.

Effective integration security planning and management are critical to ensuring that the merger or acquisition process does not result in any security breaches or disruptions to business operations.

The security pillar provides an overview of design principles, best practices, and questions. You can find prescriptive guidance on implementation in the [Security Pillar whitepaper](#).

Questions

- [MASEC 1: How do you plan to manage user and application identities across companies?](#)
- [MASEC 2: What security tools \(AWS or third-party\) do you use?](#)
- [MASEC 3: How do you plan to maintain your data security posture?](#)
- [MASEC 4: How can a company \(buyer\) gain confidence in compliance and regulatory needs?](#)
- [MASEC 5: How do you plan to maintain your network security posture?](#)
- [Resources](#)

MASEC 1: How do you plan to manage user and application identities across companies?

A well-defined plan is important to integrate identities from both companies without any impact to the end users. It is critical to have an integration plan to avoid security and compliance issues after mergers and acquisitions.

MASEC01-BP01 Use a centralized identity provider

At any given time, you can have only one directory or one SAML 2.0 identity provider connected to IAM Identity Center. But, you can change the identity source that is connected to a different one.

MASEC01-BP02 Use a common authorization approach

Companies may have a very different approach to authorization. Companies need to use a common authorization platform and develop consistent authorization policies for the combined systems.

MASEC01-BP03 Use AWS temporary credentials

You can use the AWS Security Token Service to create and provide trusted users with temporary security credentials that can control access to your AWS resources.

MASEC01-BP04 Store and use secrets securely

Use AWS Secrets Manager to replace hardcoded credentials in your code, including passwords, with an API call to Secrets Manager to retrieve the secret programmatically. The secret can't be compromised by someone examining your code because the secret no longer exists in the code.

MASEC01-BP05 Create a common policy for auditing and rotating credentials

Rotation is the process of periodically updating a secret. When you rotate a secret, you update the credentials in both the secret and the database or service. In Secrets Manager, you can set up automatic rotation for your secrets.

MASEC 2: What security tools (AWS or third-party) do you use?

Security is a shared responsibility. It is important to understand if the seller is using AWS services to find and remediate vulnerabilities, misconfigurations, and resources. Are they using third party tools to do this?

MASEC02-BP01 Use an AWS-defined process to report vulnerabilities

AWS takes security very seriously and investigates all reported vulnerabilities (for more detail, see [AWS Cloud Security](#)).

MASEC02-BP02 Use AWS services with self-service within the existing management console

On AWS, you can automate manual security tasks so you can shift your focus to scaling and innovating your business.

MASEC02-BP03 Use third-party security tools when necessary due to integration with on-premises resources

Amazon Security Lake is a fully-managed security data lake service. You can use Security Lake to automatically centralize security data from AWS and third-party sources into a data lake that's stored in your AWS account. Security Lake helps you analyze security data, so you can get a more complete understanding of your security posture across the entire organization. You can also use Security Lake to improve the protection of your workloads, applications, and data.

MASEC02-BP04 Migrate to a common set of tools, including partner tools from marketplace

The AWS Shared Responsibility Model (SRM) makes it easy to understand various choices for protecting unique AWS environment, and [access partner resources](#) that can help you implement end-to-end security quickly and easily.

MASEC02-BP05 Create a common policy for auditing and rotating credentials

For human identities, you should require users to change their passwords periodically and retire access keys in favor of temporary credentials. For machine identities, rely on temporary credentials using IAM roles. For situations where this is not possible, frequent auditing and rotating access keys is necessary.

MASEC 3: How do you plan to maintain your data security posture?

Data security must be a top priority during mergers and acquisitions given the sensitivity of risks involved. Performing security due diligence, reviewing, and implementing strong controls can help reduce risks and ensure a smooth transition. With advanced planning and oversight, data security risks that often accompany mergers and acquisitions can be effectively managed.

MASEC03-BP01 Standardize root email address (root account email access)

When you first create an AWS account, you begin with a single sign-in identity that has complete access to all AWS services and resources in the account. This identity is called the AWS account root

user and is accessed by signing in with the email address and password that you used to create the account. Ensure uninterrupted access to root email after a merger or acquisition.

MASEC03-BP02 Define data access control mechanisms for combined systems

Both organizations need a common set of privacy controls and access to data. AWS is built with comprehensive data protection in the cloud.

MASEC03-BP03 Create a consistent mechanism for data classification and protection (in-transit and at rest)

Before creating any workload, foundational practices that influence security should be in place. For example, data classification provides a way to categorize data based on levels of sensitivity, and encryption protects data by rendering it unintelligible to unauthorized access. These methods are important because they support objectives such as preventing mishandling or complying with regulatory obligations.

MASEC03-BP04 Automate data backup process for combined systems

A comprehensive backup strategy is an essential part of an organization's data protection plan to withstand, recover from, and reduce any impact that might be sustained because of a security event. Create an extensive backup strategy that defines which data must be backed up, how often data must be backed up, and how backup and recovery tasks are monitored.

MASEC03-BP05 Automate responses to data security events

AWS encourages you to use automation to help quickly detect and respond to security events within your AWS environments. In addition to increasing the speed of detection and response, automation also helps you scale your security operations as you expand your workloads running on AWS. Do you have automation process defined on both organizations?

MASEC 4: How can a company (buyer) gain confidence in compliance and regulatory needs?

Data governance establishes the processes and responsibilities that ensure the quality, consistency, and security of the data used across organizations. In case of compliance requirements due to

personal identifiable information (PII) data, the buyer needs to verify that the integrated workloads meet these requirements.

MASEC04-BP01 The seller is using AWS services (marketplace) for data governance

Data governance is a framework to build data quality checks, identify lineage (relation) between target and source datasets, and build a data catalog over existing data in data lakes and enterprise data warehouses.

MASEC04-BP02 Document consistent mechanisms for data classification

Ensure organizations are using AWS-supported partner solutions.

MASEC04-BP03 Document processes to maintain data integrity within AWS services

Regulatory requirements to maintain the integrity of data are typically implemented as part of a validated application. However, by implementing controls at the AWS service-level, you can facilitate data integrity even for actions performed outside the validated application.

MASEC04-BP04 Understand both the buyer's and seller's compliance needs

AWS supports inheritance of many security standards and compliance certifications, including PCI-DSS, HIPAA/HITECH, FedRAMP, GDPR, FIPS 140-2, and NIST 800-171, which helps you satisfy necessary compliance requirements.

MASEC 5: How do you plan to maintain your network security posture?

Both companies involved in an integration must understand each organization's network security requirements. Organizations need to understand network connectivity across regions and on-premises data centers if applicable.

MASEC05-BP01 Both organizations have documented network architecture

Network documentation includes written charts, drawings, records, and instructions of networking procedures, layouts, and information on your installed production or development network.

MASEC05-BP02 Define a strategy for overlapping Classless Inter-Domain Routing (CIDR)

In order to plan your prefix summarization and create your routing design, you should understand the IP addressing scheme of the merging or divesting companies.

MASEC05-BP03 Define a connectivity model for post-integration or divestiture

The network connectivity layer holds an enterprise's entire IT ecosystem together. Furthermore, creating the right connectivity model is a critical step toward planning your merger, acquisition, or divestiture.

MASEC05-BP04 Define a strategy for inter-enterprise DNS resolution

DNS is the typical way how users connect to applications and also how various components of an application may communicate with each other.

MASEC05-BP05 Define a security strategy for data flowing between the two enterprises

It is important to establish a secure communication between two enterprises for data transfer.

Resources

- [SEC02-BP04 Rely on a centralized identity provider](#)
- [Identity management](#)
- [AWS Compliance Programs](#)
- [Data governance](#)
- [Top 4 Networking considerations for Mergers, Acquisitions, and Divestitures](#)

Key AWS services

- [Control Tower](#)

Reliability

During mergers and acquisitions, integration reliability is a key consideration. Companies must integrate the two businesses smoothly and seamlessly, with minimal disruption to day-to-day operations. This involves carefully planning the integration process, identifying potential challenges, and developing a comprehensive integration strategy.

One of the main challenges of integration is the need to merge two different cultures, which can lead to conflict and resistance among employees. Companies must work to create a unified culture that values diversity and promotes collaboration. This requires effective communication, training, and leadership to ensure that everyone is on the same page and working towards a common goal.

Technical integration is another key consideration, as companies must verify that different systems and technologies are able to communicate and work together seamlessly. This involves extensive testing and troubleshooting to identify and resolve any issues that may arise.

Finally, companies must consider the legal and regulatory requirements of the integration process, including antitrust laws and data privacy regulations. Failure to comply with these regulations can result in significant penalties and legal risk.

Overall, integration reliability during mergers and acquisitions requires careful planning, effective communication, and a comprehensive strategy that considers both cultural and technical challenges. Companies must be committed to the integration process and invest the necessary resources required for success.

The reliability pillar provides an overview of design principles, best practices, and questions. You can find prescriptive guidance on implementation in the [Reliability Pillar whitepaper](#).

Questions

- [MAREL 1: How do you plan to manage application robustness and availability during mergers and acquisitions?](#)
- [MAREL 2: How are critical external system integrations set up for high availability to maintain your platform capabilities?](#)
- [Resources](#)

MAREL 1: How do you plan to manage application robustness and availability during mergers and acquisitions?

Establish service-level agreements (SLAs) and appropriate mechanisms for ensuring high availability. Capture the applicable SLAs and operational-level agreements (OLAs) that are relevant for the scope of the integration. Check for impact or changes required due to mergers and acquisitions. Are the SLAs and OLAs related to any third parties involved, like managed service providers?

MAREL01-BP01 Incorporate fault tolerance to achieve high availability as required for your industry vertical and customer expectations

These are two important concepts in the concept of availability. *Fault tolerance* is the ability to withstand subsystem failure and maintain availability (working properly within an established SLA). To implement fault tolerance, workloads use spare (or redundant) subsystems. *Fault isolation* minimizes the scope of impact when a failure does occur. This is typically implemented with modularization. Workloads are broken down into small subsystems that fail independently and can be repaired in isolation.

MAREL01-BP02 Establish SLAs, including DR RTO and RPO for the combined organization

Critical platforms require high availability. It is advised to achieve the maximum required availability at a reasonable cost that meets customer and business needs.

MAREL01-BP03 Establish a deployment strategy for combined company

AWS provides a number of tools to simplify and automate the provisioning of infrastructure and deployment of applications. Each deployment service offers different capabilities for managing applications. To build a successful deployment architecture, evaluate the available features of each service against the needs your application and organization.

MAREL01-BP04 Establish an SRE team and process for the combined organization.

Site reliability engineering (SRE) is the practice of using software tools to automate IT infrastructure tasks such as system management and application monitoring. Organizations use SRE to keep their software applications reliable amidst frequent updates from development teams.

MAREL 2: How are critical external system integrations set up for high availability to maintain your platform capabilities?

Core capabilities that come from external service integrations should be reviewed. These are out of your control and could be a concern, especially if they are backing mission-critical capabilities.

MAREL02-BP01 Establish alternatives for each critical external service to switch over to if needed, or balance traffic across

Amazon API Gateway can be used to front calls to backend external services and handle failover if problems are detected with the primary service.

MAREL02-BP02 Have legal agreements in place guaranteeing the right of continued usage of all external services

As an example, see [AWS Service Terms](#).

Resources

- [Designing highly available distributed systems on AWS](#)
- [AWS Architecture Center](#)
- [Fault tolerance and fault isolation](#)

Key AWS services

- [AWS Elastic Disaster Recovery](#)
- [AWS Networking and Content Delivery](#)

Performance efficiency

The performance efficiency pillar includes the ability to use computing resources efficiently to meet system requirements, and to maintain that efficiency as demand changes and technologies evolve.

The most important details are to identify and isolate performance bottlenecks before and after the merger, monitor performance during and after the merger, tune queries and indexes, use data compression and partitioning, and keep up with hardware and software maintenance. These steps help maintain performance efficiency during mergers and acquisitions, and ensure that the combined system can handle increased workloads.

The performance efficiency pillar provides an overview of design principles, best practices, and questions. You can find prescriptive guidance on implementation in the [Performance Efficiency Pillar whitepaper](#).

Questions

- [MAPERF 1: How do you select the best performing architecture between two organizations?](#)
- [MAPERF 2: How does the platform scale and maintain performance as more customer load is added?](#)
- [Resources](#)

MAPERF 1: How do you select the best performing architecture between two organizations?

Support increased platform loading, which allows more customer usage and drives company growth. The platform hosting could be statically provisioned and have very predictable loading. Scaling can be accomplished by both vertical and horizontal methods.

MAPERF01-BP01 Understand the available services and resources

Explore the wide range of services and resources available in the cloud. Identify the relevant services and configuration options for your workload, and determine how to achieve optimal performance.

MAPERF01-BP02 Define a process for architectural choices

Define a process to choose resources and services by using internal experience and knowledge of the cloud or external resources such as published use cases, relevant documentation, or whitepapers. You should define a process that encourages experimentation and benchmarking with any services that could be used in your workload.

MAPERF01-BP03 Factor cost requirements into decisions

Workloads often have cost requirements for operation. Use internal cost controls to select resource types and sizes based on predicted resource need.

MAPERF01-BP04 Use guidance from your cloud provider or an appropriate partner

Use cloud company resources, such as solutions architects, professional services, or an appropriate partner to guide your decisions. These resources can help review and improve your architecture for optimal performance.

MAPERF01-BP05 Benchmark workloads from both organization

Benchmark the performance of an existing workload to understand how it performs in the cloud. Use the data collected from benchmarks to make architectural decisions.

MAPERF 2: How does the platform scale and maintain performance as more customer load is added?

General support of increased platform loading, which allows for more customer usage and drive company growth. The platform hosting could be statically provisioned and have very predictable loading. Scaling can be accomplished by vertical as well as horizontal methods.

MAPERF02-BP01 Scale current architecture and hosting through manual or automatic means

Take progressive steps to achieve scaling.

MAPERF02-BP02 Remediate bottlenecks that prevent scaling, and use automatic scaling or serverless resources when appropriate

Serverless technologies feature automatic scaling, built-in high availability, and a pay-for-use billing model to increase agility. Serverless technologies reduce infrastructure management tasks like capacity provisioning. For more detail, see [Serverless on AWS](#).

MAPERF02-BP03 Perform periodic static provisioning for peak usage in reaction to monitoring data

Review historical data to understand peak usage days and time. Manually pre-provision resources based on historical data findings.

MAPERF02-BP04 Rearchitect to scale for new customers

Cloud solutions architects should ideally build an architecture with the future in mind, meaning their solutions need to cater to current scale requirements as well as the anticipated growth of the solution. This growth can be either the organic growth of a solution, or it could be related to a merger and acquisition scenario where its size is increased dramatically within a short period of time.

Resources

- [Disaster Recovery \(DR\) Architecture on AWS, Part I: Strategies for Recovery in the Cloud](#)
- [AWS Multi-Region Fundamentals](#)
- [AWS Architecture Center](#)
- [AWS Auto Scaling](#)

Cost optimization

During mergers and acquisitions, integrating cost optimization concerns is a critical aspect of achieving successful outcomes. Companies must carefully evaluate the cost structure of the target company to identify areas where costs can be reduced without compromising operations or quality. This involves analyzing financial statements, operational processes, and labor costs to identify opportunities for cost savings.

Companies should also consider the impact of integration on the cost structure, including the costs associated with integrating IT systems, consolidating facilities, and reducing redundancies. Effective cost optimization requires a detailed understanding of the target company's operations, financial performance, and market dynamics. By carefully planning and performing integration efforts, companies can achieve significant cost savings while maintaining operational efficiency and quality.

The cost optimization pillar provides an overview of design principles, best practices, and questions. You can find prescriptive guidance on implementation in the [Cost Optimization Pillar whitepaper](#).

Questions

- [MACOST 1: How is cost optimization progressing with AWS hosting for both companies?](#)
- [MACOST 2: How do you plan to monitor usage and cost of combined organizations?](#)
- [MACOST 3: How do you plan for data transfer and storage charges in case of required data integration after mergers and acquisitions activity?](#)
- [Resources](#)

MACOST 1: How is cost optimization progressing with AWS hosting for both companies?

Carelessness or lack of oversight can cut into company profitability and growth. Reducing costs can likely be achieved and savings can be reinvested to improve the growth of a company. Establish policies and procedures to monitor and appropriately allocate your costs. This allows you to measure and improve the cost efficiency of workloads. Perform pricing model analysis for combined entity feature in AWS Cost Explorer.

MACOST01-BP01 Perform pricing model analysis for the combined entities

Analyze each component of the workload. Determine if the component and resources should be running for extended periods (for commitment discounts) or dynamic and short-running (for Spot or On-Demand Instances). Perform an analysis on the workload using the recommendations feature in AWS Cost Explorer.

MACOST01-BP02 Optimize accounts through various means, such as EC2 instance types, Savings Plans, and Amazon S3 lifecycle

Use AWS Trusted Advisor to examine current cost savings and possible additional savings.

MACOST01-BP03 Discover and realize additional cost savings

Explore means for additional cost savings, and use AWS Cost Explorer to evaluate costs. Choose an optimized savings plan for the combined entity, and work with AWS teams to use Reserve Instances or Savings Plans across companies if possible.

MACOST01-BP04 Migrate to Regions based on cost

Resource pricing can be different in each Region. Factoring in Region cost verifies that you are paying the lowest overall price for a workload.

MACOST01-BP05 Use managed services for lower TCO

Understand how proper use of managed services can lower TCO.

MACOST01-BP06 Select third-party agreements with cost efficient terms

Cost-efficient agreements and terms scale the cost of these services with the benefits they provide. Select agreements and pricing that scale when they provide additional benefits to your organization.

MACOST 2: How do you plan to monitor usage and cost of combined organizations?

Establish policies and procedures to monitor and appropriately allocate your costs. This allows you to measure and improve the cost efficiency of workloads.

MACOST02-BP01 Configure billing and cost management tools across both organizations

Configure AWS Cost Explorer and AWS Budgets in line with your organization policies.

MACOST02-BP02 Combine both organizations information to cost and usage

To roll your new AMS-managed AWS account bill into a payment for an existing AWS Organizations management account, set up consolidated billing, and link the accounts.

MACOST02-BP03 Allocate costs based on workload metrics

Organize the workload's costs by metrics or business outcomes to measure workload cost efficiency. Implement a process to analyze the AWS Cost and Usage Report with Amazon Athena, which can provide insight and chargeback capability.

MACOST02-BP04 Configure a bill or chargeback strategy using custom usage tags

MACOST 3: How do you plan for data transfer and storage charges in case of required data integration after mergers and acquisitions activity?

Plan and monitor data transfer charges so that you can make architectural decisions to minimize costs. A small yet effective architectural change can drastically reduce your operational costs over time.

MACOST03-BP01 Perform data transfer modeling

Gather organization requirements, and perform data transfer modeling of the workload and each of its components. This identifies the lowest cost point for its current data transfer requirements.

MACOST03-BP02 Select components to optimize data transfer cost

All components are selected, and architecture is designed to reduce data transfer costs. This includes using components such as wide-area-network (WAN) optimization and multi-Availability Zone (AZ) configurations.

MACOST03-BP03 Implement services to reduce data transfer costs

Implement services to reduce data transfer. For example, using a content delivery network (CDN) such as Amazon CloudFront to deliver content to users, caching layers using Amazon ElastiCache, or using AWS Direct Connect instead of VPN for connectivity to AWS.

MACOST03-BP04 Delete redundant data stores using policies

Manage the lifecycle of all your data, and automatically enforce deletion timelines to minimize the total storage requirements of your workload.

MACOST03-BP05 Analyze data integration pattern of the combined organizations

Data is a combined organizational asset. Collect, store, organize, and process valuable data, and make it available in a secure way to the people and applications that need it.

Resources

- [Well-Architected Cost Optimization Labs](#)
- [Cost Optimization with AWS](#)
- [What to consider when selecting a Region](#)
- [COST07-BP03 Select third-party agreements with cost-efficient terms](#)

Sustainability

The sustainability pillar provides design principles, operational guidance, best-practices, and improvement plans to meet sustainability targets for your AWS workloads.

The sustainability impact of mergers and acquisitions can be positive or negative, depending on a variety of factors.

Acquisitions can lead to increased efficiency, reduced costs, and expanded market opportunities, but they can also lead to increased resource consumption, pollution, and deforestation. For example, if two companies merge, they may consolidate their operations, which could lead to increased energy consumption, water use, and waste generation.

In addition, acquisitions can lead to the loss of biodiversity, increased greenhouse gas emissions, and other negative environmental impacts. If the acquired company has poor environmental practices, this can be exacerbated by the merger.

On the other hand, if the acquired company has strong environmental practices, this can be a positive factor in the merger. The acquired company may have new technologies or processes that can help the acquiring company reduce its environmental impact.

Overall, the sustainability impact of an integration depends on a variety of factors, including the companies involved, the products and services they offer, and the environmental practices of the companies. It is important for companies to consider the potential sustainability impacts of mergers and acquisitions before proceeding.

You can find prescriptive guidance on implementation in the [Sustainability Pillar whitepaper](#).

Questions

- [MASUS 1: How can we verify that the acquired company aligns with our sustainability goals?](#)
- [MASUS 2: How can we make sustainability a priority during the post-acquisition integration process?](#)
- [Resources](#)

MASUS 1: How can we verify that the acquired company aligns with our sustainability goals?

Discuss sustainability vision and priorities with seller's executives, managers and sustainability staff. Important to gauge leadership buy-in and competence on sustainability issues. Consider sustainability terms in the acquisition agreement. If possible, include specific environmental, social or governance targets seller must achieve within a certain time period post acquisition and develop a post-acquisition integration plan.

MASUS01-BP01 Perform due diligence

Thoroughly investigate the acquired company's sustainability practices, including their environmental impact, social responsibility, and governance. Identify areas of alignment and improvement.

MASUS01-BP02 Establish clear sustainability objectives

Define the sustainability goals and targets that you want the acquired company to achieve. Ensure that these objectives align with your organization's sustainability strategy.

MASUS01-BP03 Integrate sustainability into the acquisition process

Incorporate sustainability considerations into the due diligence process and valuation of the company. This could include assessing the company's carbon footprint, energy usage, supply chain practices, and community engagement.

MASUS01-BP04 Communicate expectations

Communicate your sustainability expectations and requirements to the acquired company's management and employees. Educate on the importance of sustainability and the required commitment to achieving your organization's goals.

MASUS01-BP05 Provide resources and support

Provide the acquired company with the necessary resources and support to achieve your sustainability objectives. Include training, funding for sustainability initiatives, or access to experts in the field.

MASUS 2: How can we make sustainability a priority during the post-acquisition integration process?

Encourage a culture of sustainability within the organization by providing training, education, and opportunities for employees to get involved in sustainability initiatives. Integrate sustainability considerations into business processes and decision-making to ensure sustainability is considered in all aspects of the organization's operations post integration. Collaborate with external partners, such as suppliers and customers, to align sustainability goals and initiatives and build partnerships for long-term sustainability.

MASUS02-BP01 Establish a sustainability committee

Create a team of individuals from both organizations to oversee sustainability initiatives during the integration process. This committee should develop a plan for integrating sustainability into the new organization's operations and ensure that it remains a priority.

MASUS02-BP02 Conduct a sustainability audit

Before the acquisition, conduct a thorough audit of each organization's sustainability practices to identify areas of strength and weakness. This audit helps you understand the current state of sustainability within the organization and identifies opportunities for improvement.

MASUS02-BP03 Communicate the importance of sustainability

Communicate the importance of sustainability to all employees, stakeholders, and customers. Make sure everyone understands why sustainability is important and how it fits into the organization's long-term goals.

MASUS02-BP04 Integrate sustainability into the integration plan

Incorporate sustainability into the overall integration plan. This may involve developing new policies and procedures, identifying areas where sustainability can be improved, and setting goals and metrics for sustainability performance.

MASUS02-BP05 Monitor and evaluate sustainability performance

Regularly monitor and evaluate the organization's sustainability performance to ensure that progress is being made. This may involve collecting data on energy usage, waste generation, and other sustainability metrics and using this data to identify areas for improvement.

For further details on sustainability, see [Sustainability Pillar - AWS Well-Architected Framework](#).

Resources

- [AWS enables sustainability solutions](#)

Conclusion

Mergers and acquisitions can be complex and challenging, particularly when it comes to integrating two separate organizations and ensuring that the acquired business aligns with the existing organization's culture and strategy. However, by using a six-pillar approach described in this whitepaper, companies can successfully integrate acquired businesses and drive long-term value for the shareholders.

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Document revisions

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Change	Description	Date
Initial publication	Mergers and Acquisitions Lens first published.	May 15, 2024

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AWS Glossary

For the latest AWS terminology, see the [AWS glossary](#) in the *AWS Glossary Reference*.